

Seneca

POLYTECHNIC

Entrepreneurship & Innovation Work Integrated Learning
EWIL Program
Session Two

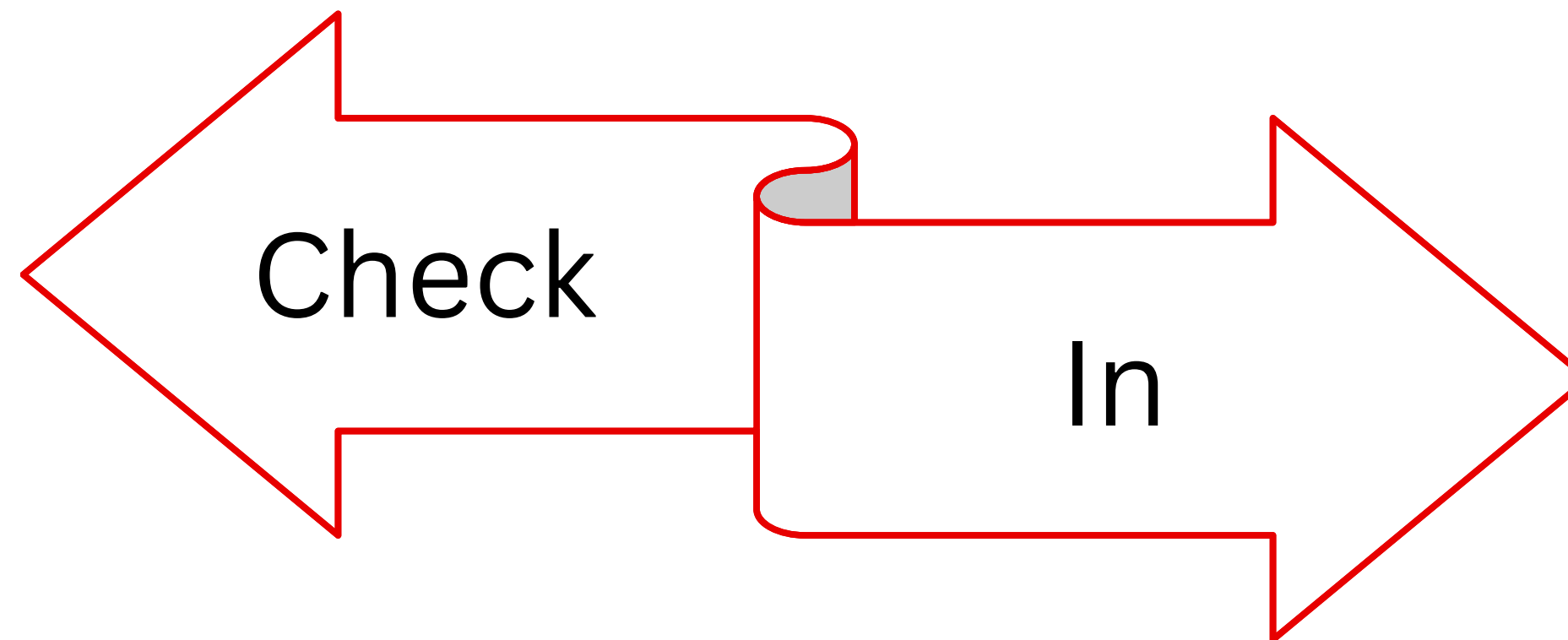
Questions?

Need Help / Give Help!

 Visible to students ▼

This forum is to post any questions you may have about this course. This is a forum for peer to peer dialogue. If you know the answer, let us know! As well, this forum can be used throughout the course to post any questions you might have.





Problem Slide

Seneca HELIX



Resources

Pitch Deck Template

Problem Slide



50 % of all adults

High Priority

Problem

This is where you introduce the problem you are solving. You may choose to tell a story or share statistics. Make it compelling. Consider including data and research.

Problem Slide

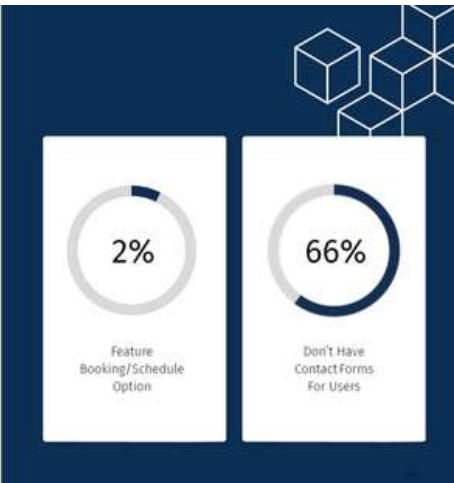


Problem - Examples

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Problem

There are over 2 million 'lawyer' related Google searches made in Canada, every year.



Aerios - A platform to find lawyers

The Problem



of charities & non-profits in Canada do not have a digital strategy

HeroHub - Find volunteer opportunities

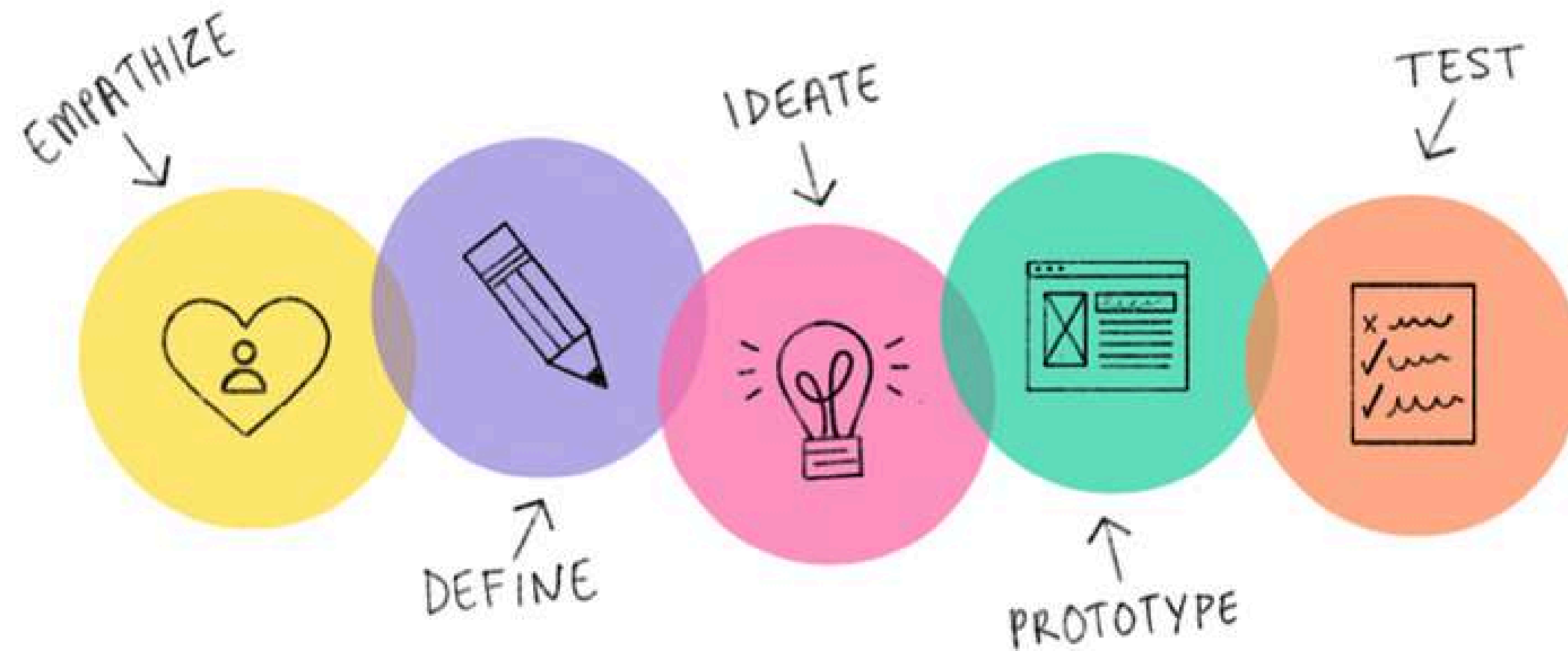
Strategic Thinking

1. Design Thinking Intro
2. Market Research
3. Persona
4. Selecting a Niche
5. Mission, Vision and Values

3:00 PM to 4:00 PM - Seneca Library's Research Session



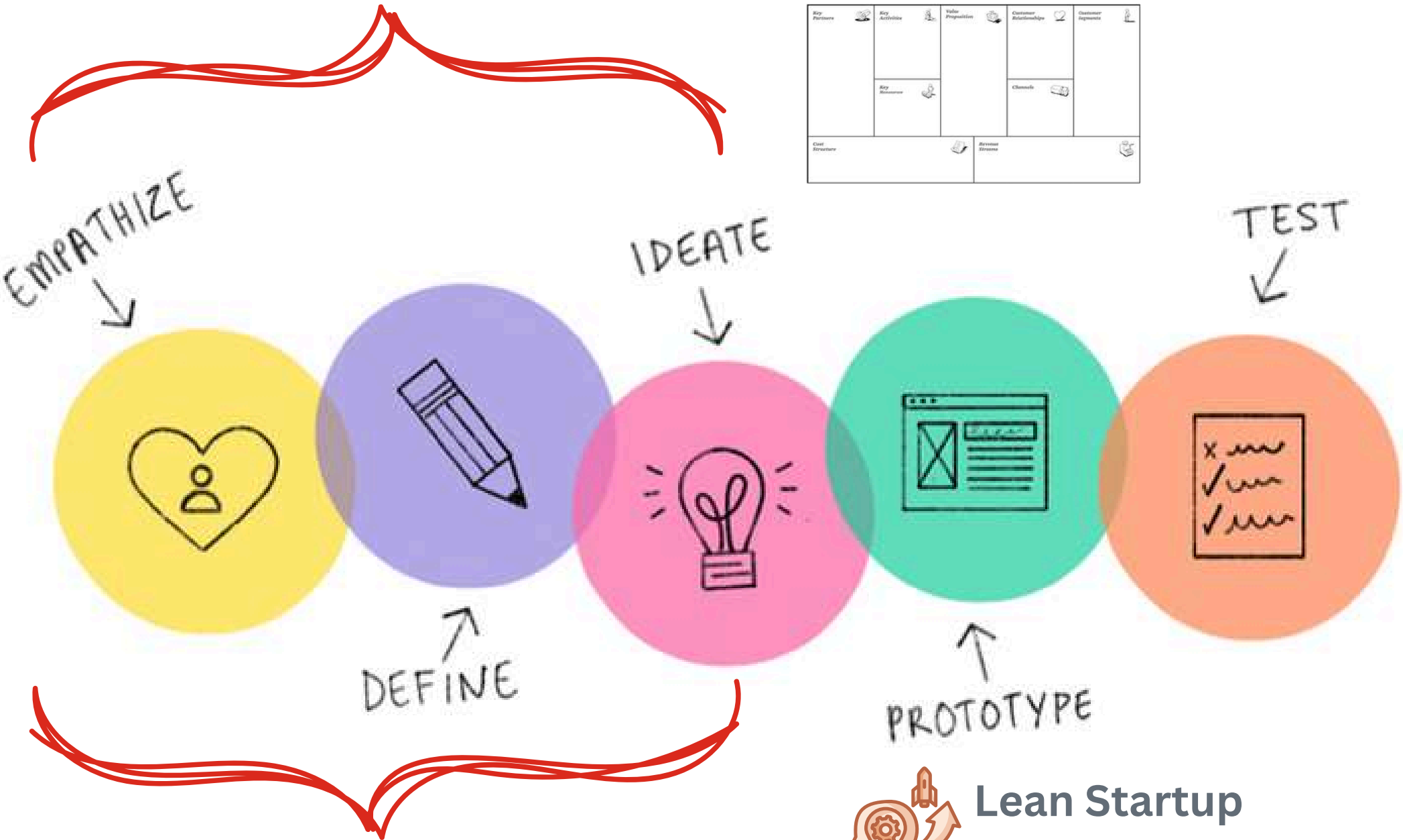
Design Thinking



Business Model Canvas

Key Partners	Key Activities	Value Proposition	Customer Relationships	Customer Segments
	Key Resources		Channels	
Cost Structure		Revenue Streams		

 User Persona

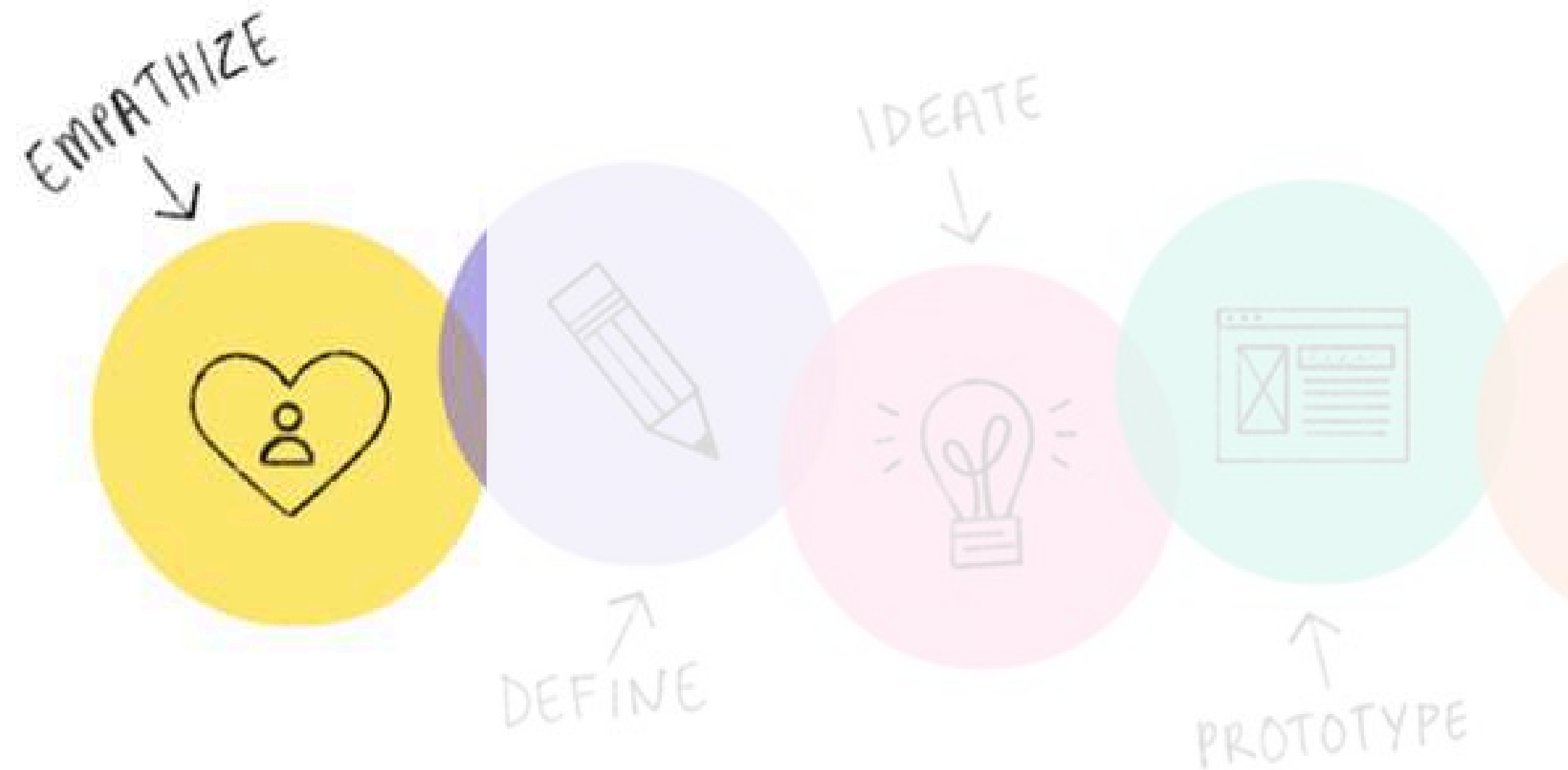


 Problem Statements
and Market Research

 Lean Startup
Methodology

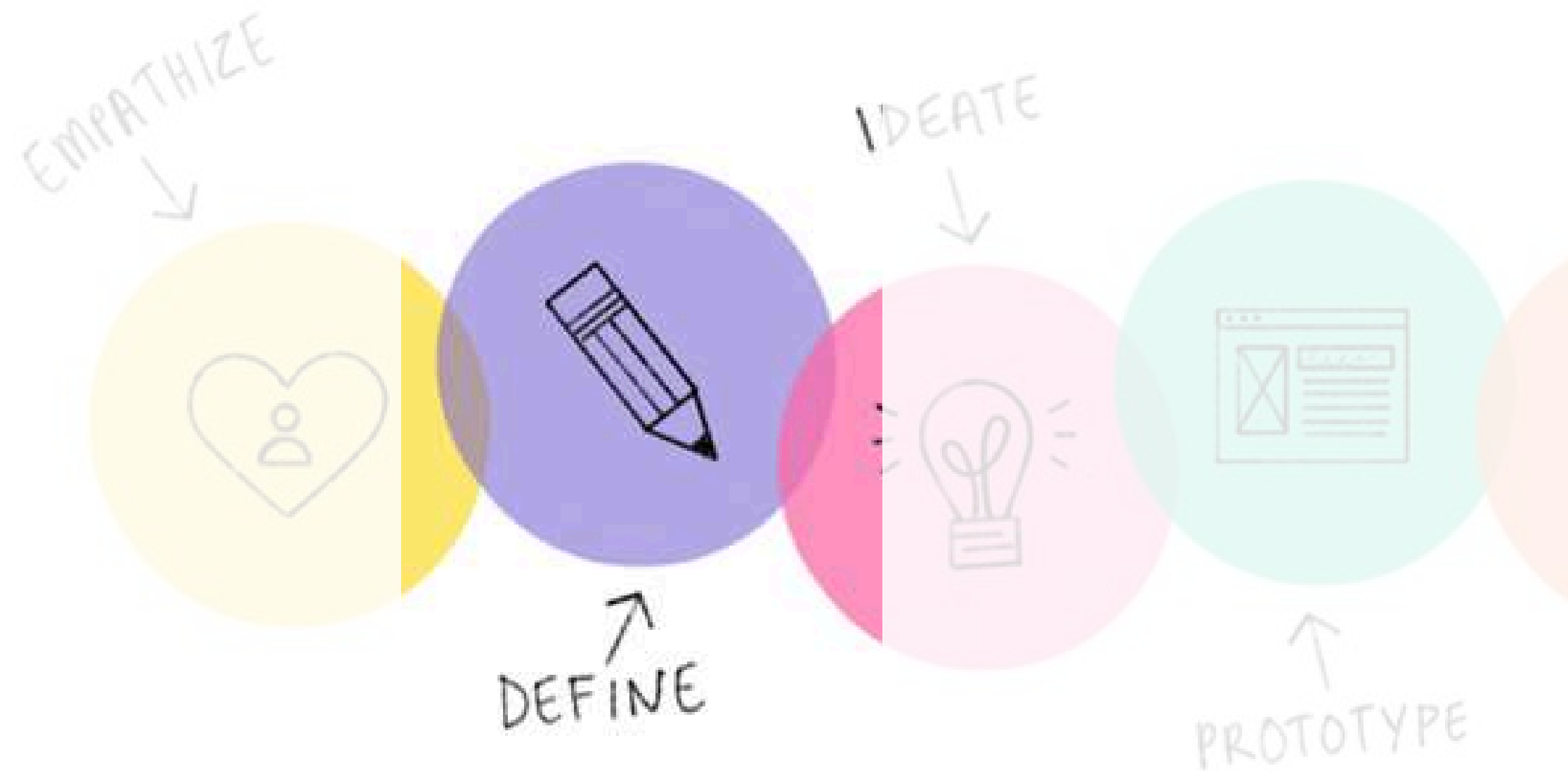
Empathize

Develop a deep understanding of the challenge/problem.



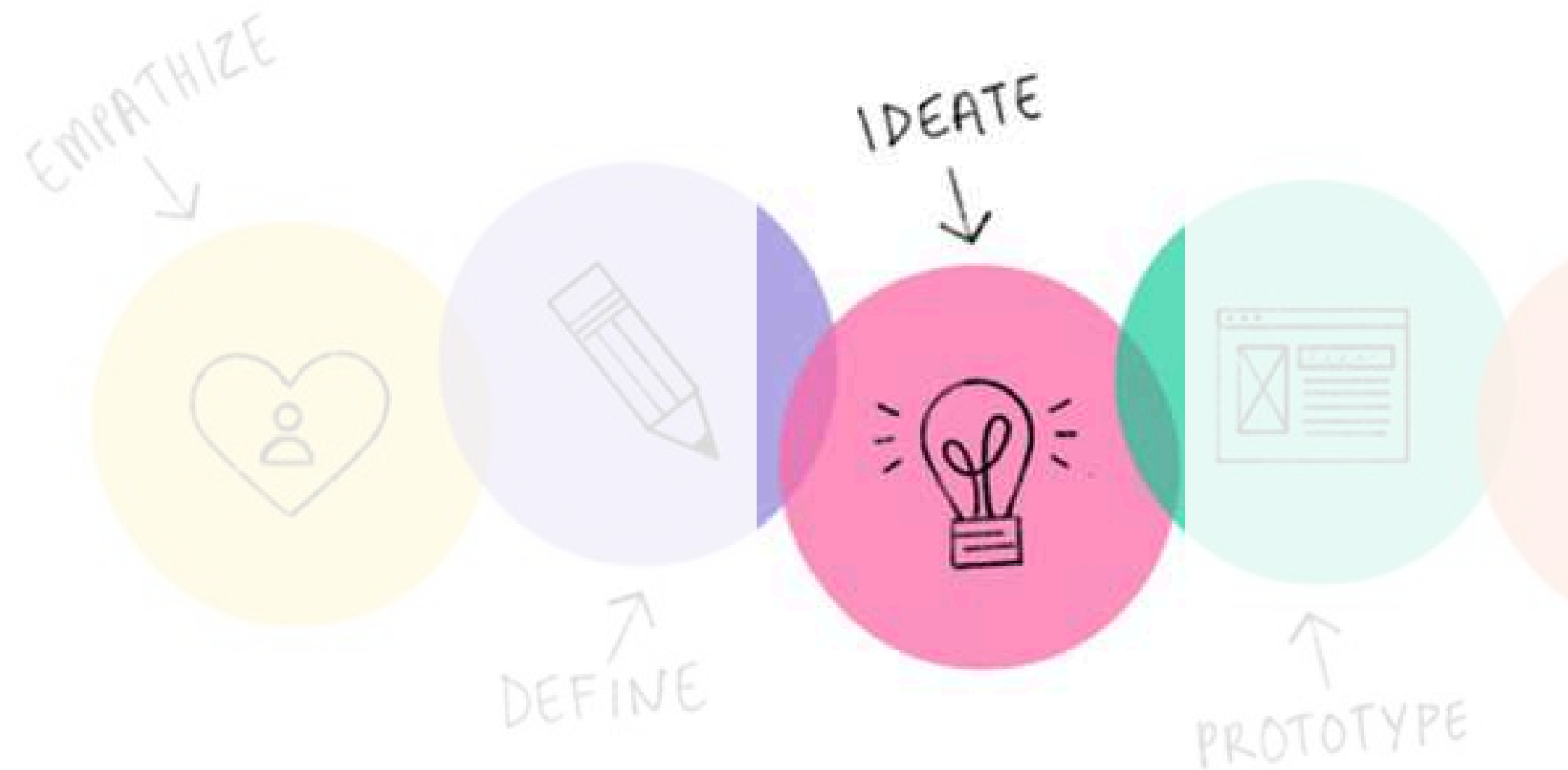
Define

Clearly articulate the problem you want to solve.



Ideate

Brainstorm potential solutions; select and develop your solution.



Start-ups that have used design thinking



The founders used design thinking to deeply understand the concerns of both hosts and guests.

Start-ups that have used design thinking

Uber

Uber focused on user experience by addressing pain points such as cost transparency, ride tracking, and ease of booking through a mobile app.

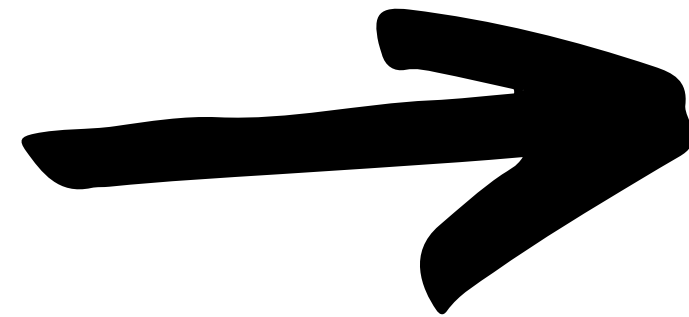
Start-ups that have used design thinking

Uber

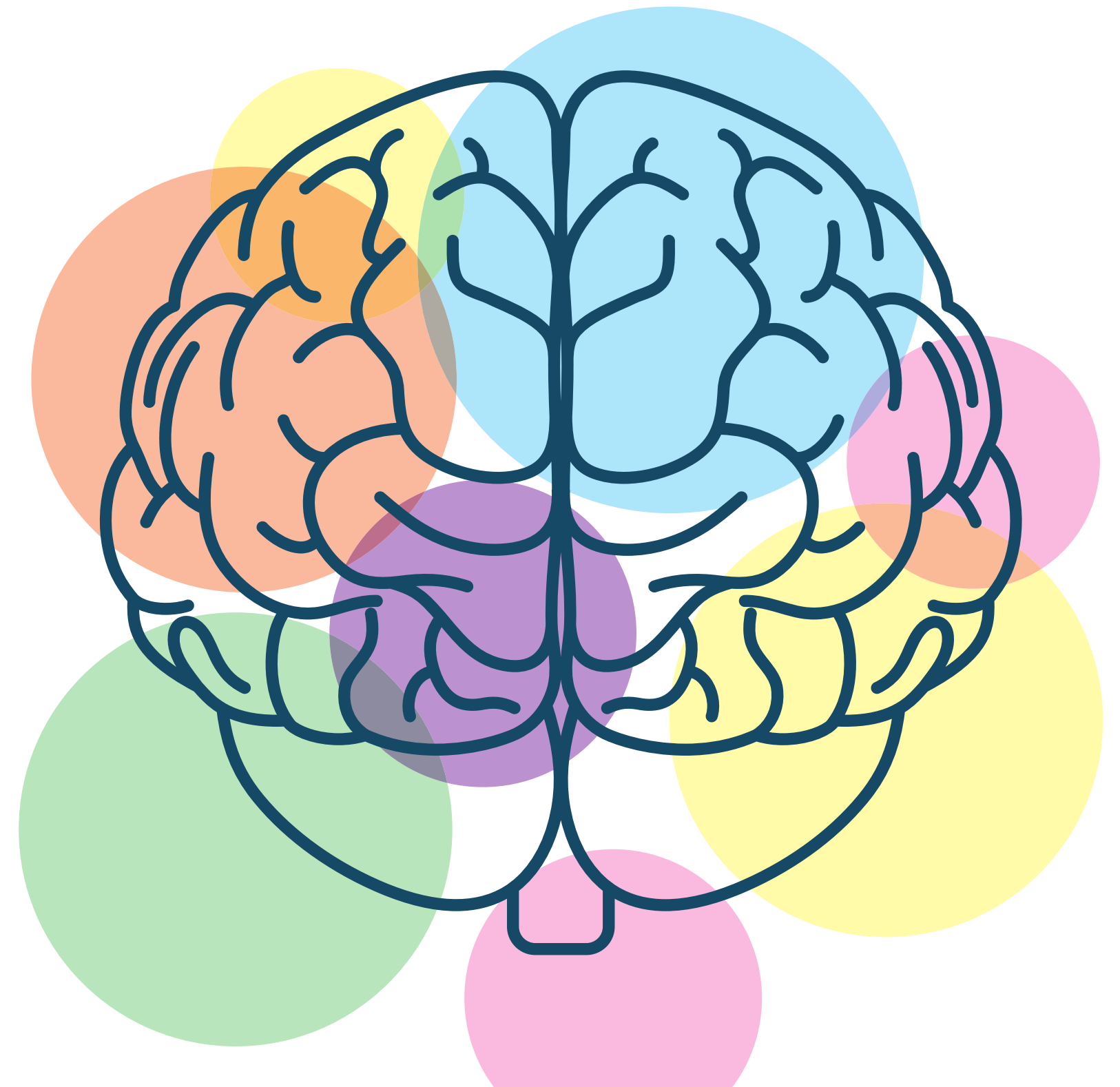
What did this lead to?

Start-ups that have used design thinking

Uber



Developing an Innovative Mindset



Improve Existing Businesses



What are some ways we can improve a traditional barber shop/salon?

Improve Existing Businesses



What are some ways we can improve a traditional barber shop/salon?

- **Unpredictable wait times**
 - Customers sometimes wait up to 30–45 minutes before their turn. A 2023 consumer survey found that 62% of customers are frustrated by unpredictable wait times in service-based businesses (Statista).
- **First-come-first-serve system**
 - In urban barbershops, peak wait times can double during weekends compared to weekdays (local business reports, Toronto).
- **Manual check-in process**
 - Customers must verbally confirm with staff or wait to be acknowledged. A Deloitte study showed that 48% of customers prefer digital self check-ins over manual processes in service industries.
- **Time lost between haircuts**
 - Cleaning up hair and sanitizing tools between customers slows down operations. On average, 3–5 minutes per customer is spent sweeping and sanitizing, which adds up to nearly 45 minutes of “non-billable” time per barber in an 8-hour shift (operations observation).
- **Cash-only or manual payment methods**
 - According to Payments Canada (2022), cash use in Canada has dropped below 10% of total transactions, with debit/credit and digital wallets preferred by 85% of consumers.
- **Limited visibility for customers**
 - Customers don’t always know their place in the queue or how long they’ll wait. A study by Queue-it (2021) found that 73% of customers perceive wait times as shorter.
- **Customer experience is highly dependent on barber availability**
 - A Yelp business insight suggests that 40% of customers prefer booking with a specific service provider, not just “first available.”
- **Physical space gets crowded**
 - In small barbershops (under 600 sq. ft.), seating is limited to 6–8 customers, leading to standing-room-only conditions during peak weekend hours.

Improve Existing Businesses



What are some ways we can improve a traditional barber shop/salon?

Observing 10 customers

- **3/10 customers were late**
 - Customers found out about the barbershop through word-of-mouth but were unable to find an address
- **6/10 customers were frustrated waiting**
 - Customers did not know when their turn was coming up
- **2/10 Customers had to run to the bank**
 - They did not have cash on them
- **3/10 customers were standing**
 - There was not enough seating in the waiting area

Improve Existing Businesses

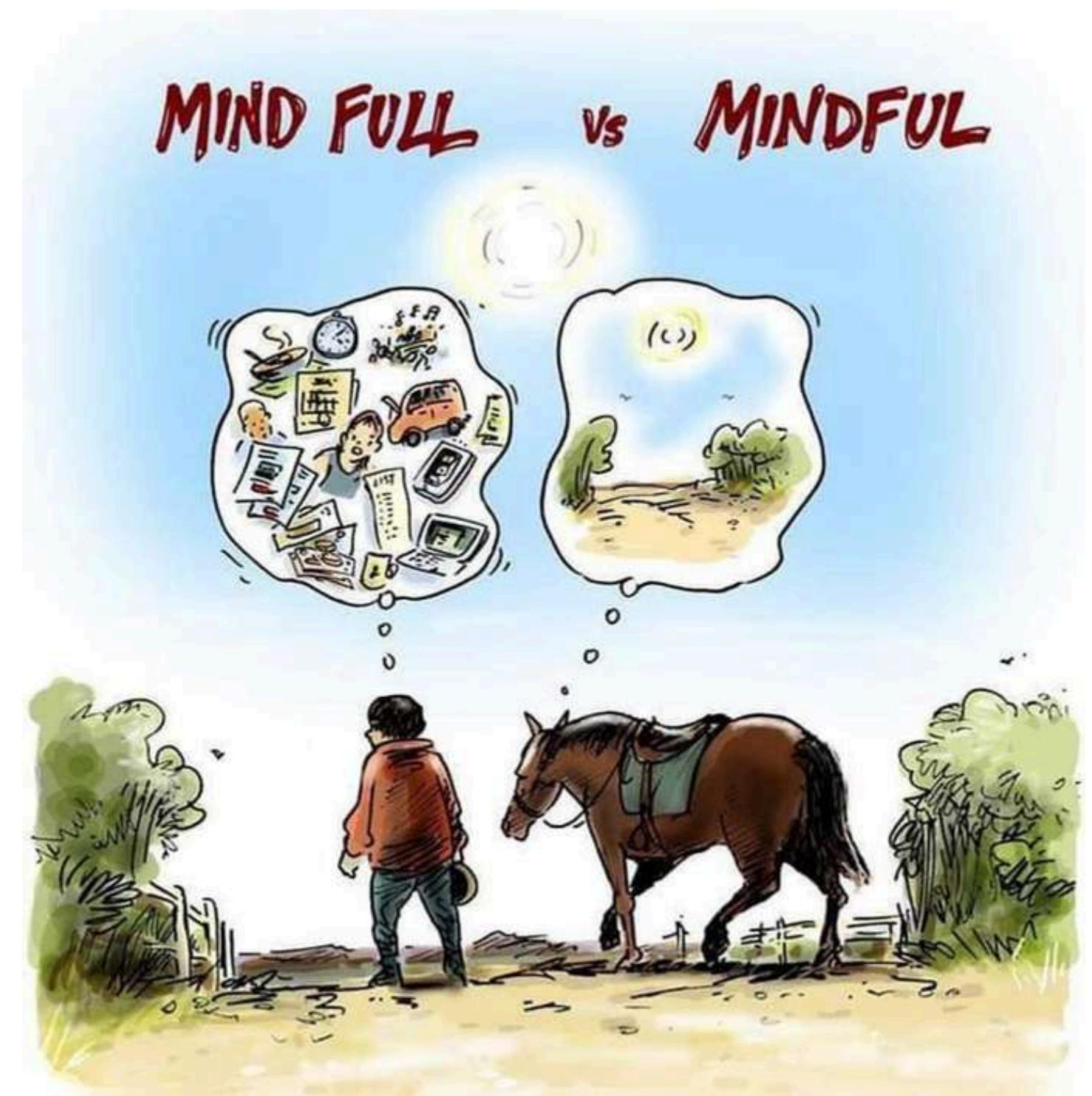


- Online Booking
- Online Payment
- Google business listing
- CRM Tool
- Digital Queuing System
- Self Check-in Kiosk

Mind full, or Mindful?

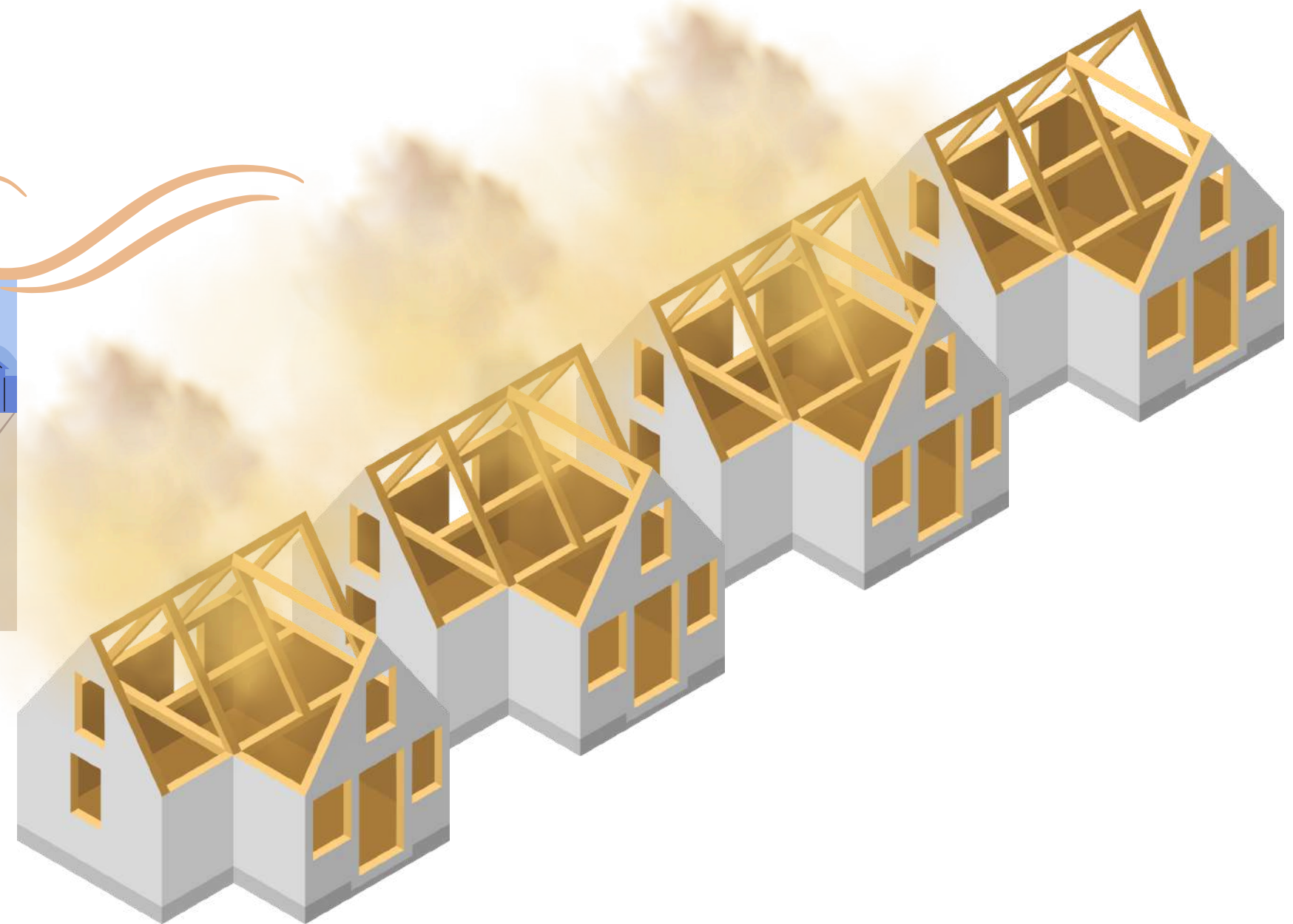
Awareness and observation open your eyes to the opportunities that surround you, highlighting both the wonders and the challenges.

Be Observant.



Class Activity

Mind full, or Mindful? - New Houses/Development Area

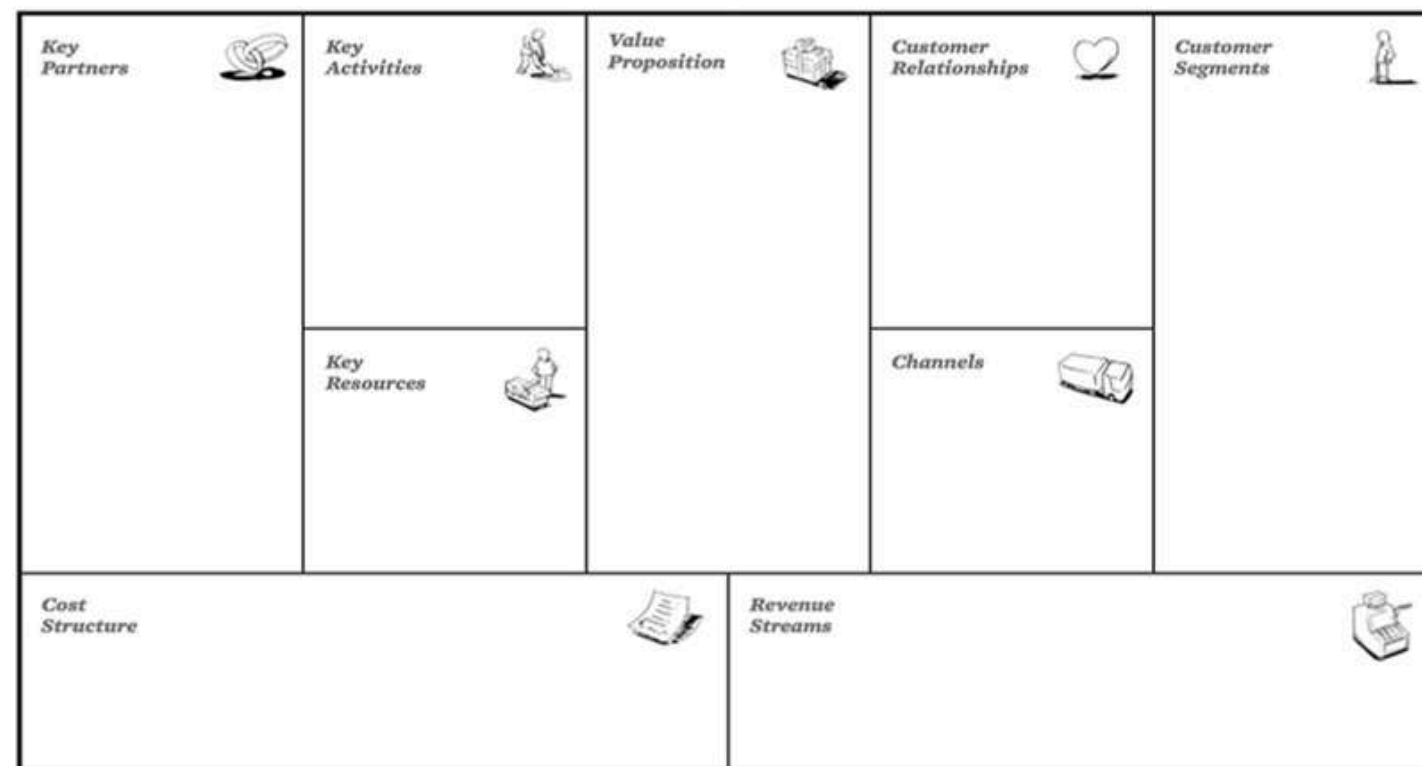


Class Activity

Mind full, or Mindful? - Cars Nearby



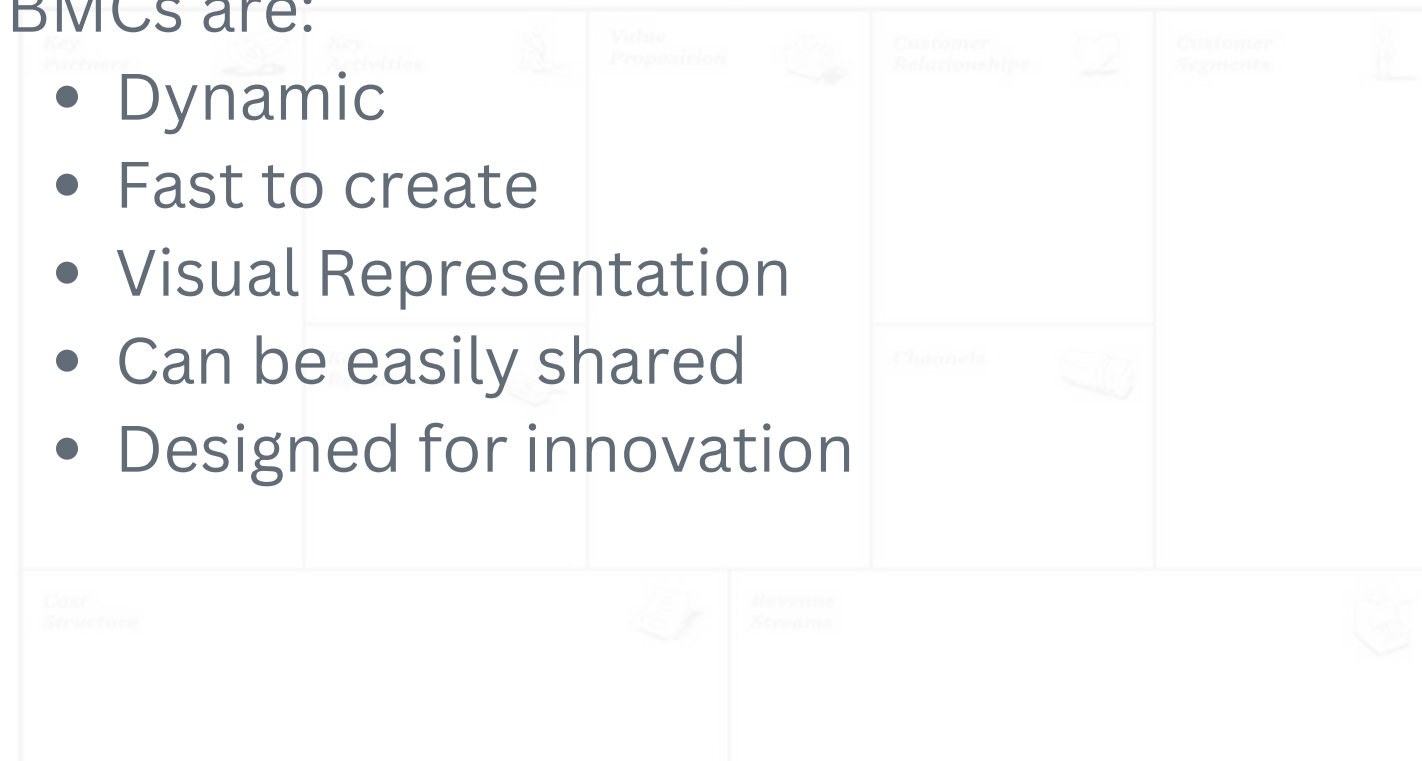
Business Model Canvas vs. Business Plan



Business Model Canvas vs. Business Plan

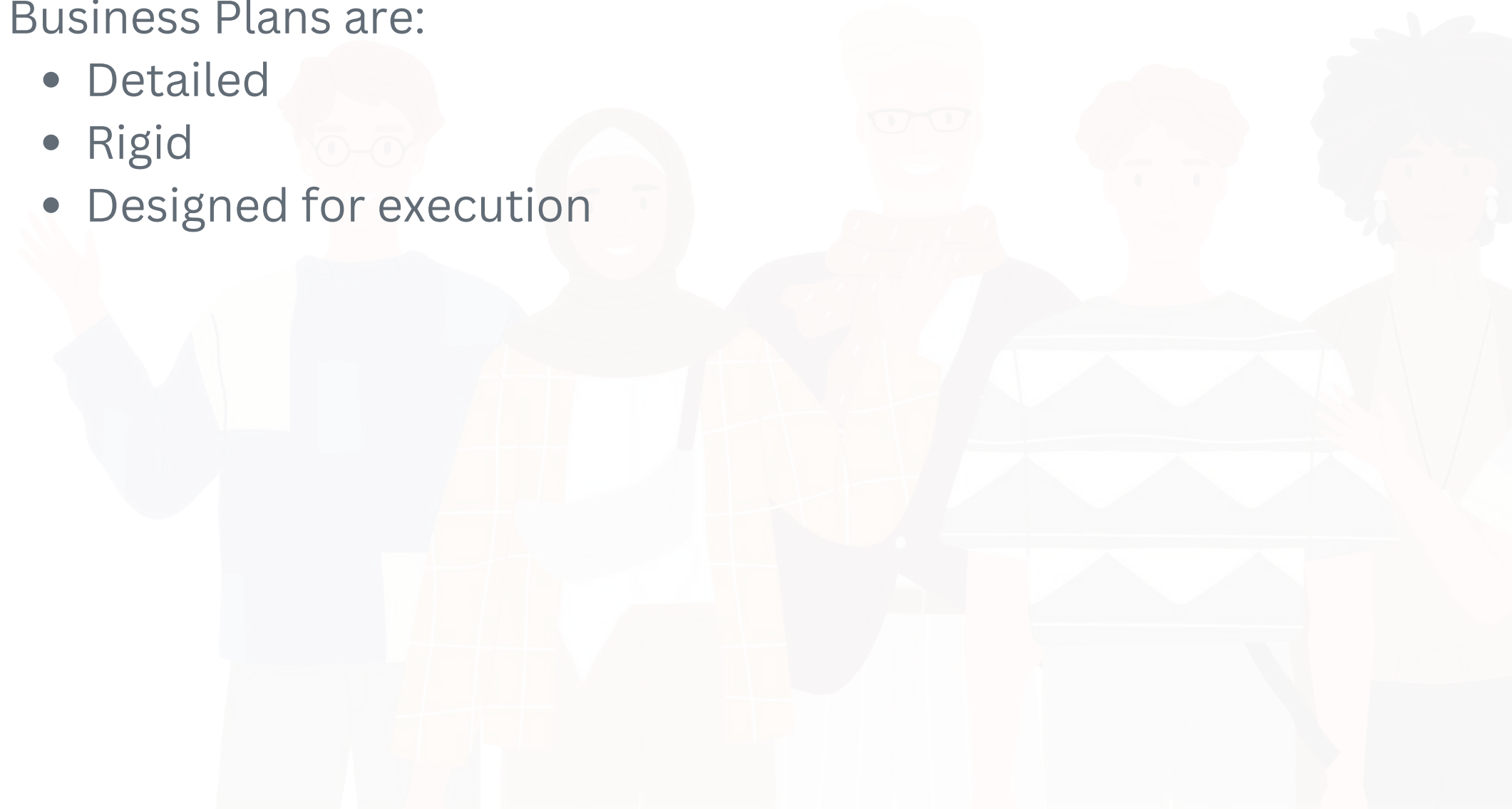
BMCs are:

- Dynamic
- Fast to create
- Visual Representation
- Can be easily shared
- Designed for innovation



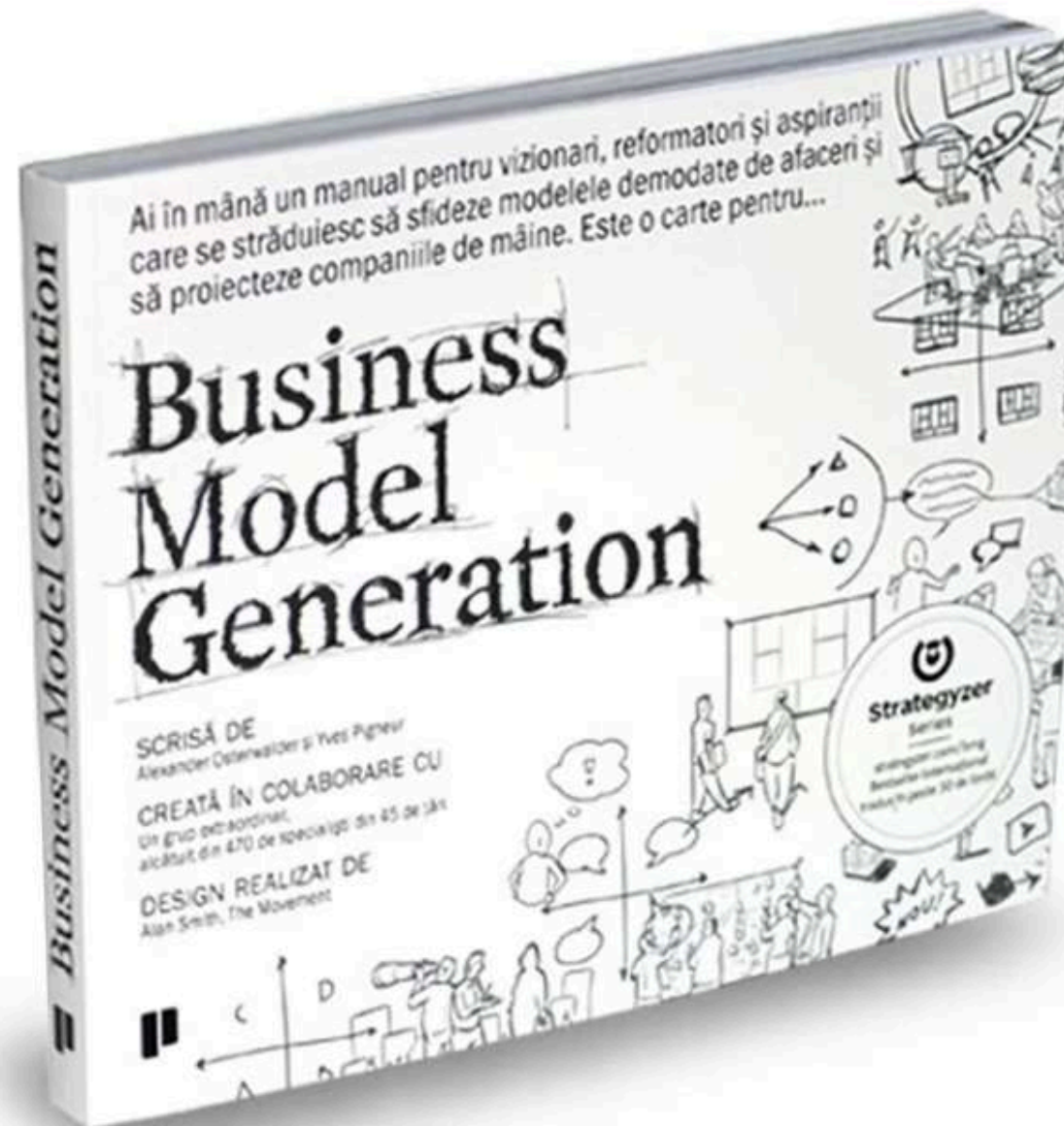
Business Plans are:

- Detailed
- Rigid
- Designed for execution



Strategic Thinking

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What is a User Persona?

Personas are used to “create reliable and realistic representations of your key audience segments”

- Semi-fictional
- Grouping of actual individual users
- Persona = Person + Activity



Why create User Personas?

- User-centric design - map user centric perspective.
- Can't be everything to everyone.
- Need to choose whose problems you are trying to solve.



Class Activity

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Class Activity

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Airbnb is a two-sided market!

Class Activity

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Travelers looking for affordable, safe, and local accommodations. This helped them understand what information hosts need to display on their listing.

Property owners looking for additional income.

Class Activity

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Class Activity

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Non-technical small business owners who needed simple, effective email marketing tools.

Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Who are the users for the following start-ups?



Independent pharmacy owners that have a website but no eCommerce solution.

Clients who are looking for products low in stock.

Curiosity in Identifying Needs

In-Depth Exploration

- Take your time to observe the specifics of your 'customers'
- Identify what frustrates, confuses, or satisfies them
- Consider what can reduce friction and enhance their delight
- Explore how individuals currently address the issue
- Pay attention to what people think, feel, do, hear, see, sense, smell, and touch
- Delve into the root causes of these problems (Utilize the 5 Whys technique)



Gather Information



Stay Objective & Unbiased



Do not jump to solutions - the goal is to dive deep into the problem.



Gather Information

Primary & Secondary Research

Secondary research involves gathering data that has already been collected and published by others.

It is a cost-effective and efficient way to understand:

- market trends
- consumer behavior
- competitive landscapes

Secondary research is especially useful in the problem-finding phase, where entrepreneurs need to identify existing gaps, challenges, and opportunities within a given market or industry.

Why Secondary Research?

- Cost-Effective
- Time-Saving
- Broad Insights
- Foundation for Primary Research



Steps for Conducting Secondary Research

Define Your Research Objectives:

- Pinpoint the specific problem area you wish to investigate (e.g., market gaps, customer pain points, industry challenges).
- Clarify the information needed to thoroughly understand the issue (e.g., market size, competitor analysis, customer feedback).

Identify Sources of Secondary Data:

- Utilize a diverse range of sources to collect extensive data. Some may be free, while others could require subscriptions or purchases.

Analyze the Data:

- Search for patterns, gaps, and trends that highlight problems or opportunities.
- Cross-compare data from various sources to verify accuracy and maintain consistency.

Use Data to Identify Problems:

- Once data is collected, evaluate which market segments or areas exhibit unmet needs, ineffective solutions, or declining trends. These often point to problems that can be addressed with innovative solutions.

Sources for Secondary Research

- Industry Reports (Statista)
- Government Publications & Databases (StatsCan)
- Academic Journals & Research Papers
- News Outlets & Magazines
- Competitor Websites & Marketing Materials
- Social Media & Forums (Reddit)



Secondary Research

Class Activity

Problem Finding Exercise

1. **Choose a Problem Area:** Select an industry or topic that interests you (e.g., health tech, education, sustainable fashion).
2. **Conduct Secondary Research:** Use at least three different sources (e.g., industry reports, government data, social media) to gather insights into the current challenges or problems in this area.
3. **Identify Problems:** Based on the data you've collected, write down 2-3 specific problems or gaps that could be potential business opportunities.
4. **Present Findings:** Share your findings with the group, explaining how secondary research helped you uncover these problems.



Form Your Problem Statement

For (user persona), who is facing (problem or challenge), the current solutions (limitations of existing solutions, if applicable).

How might we (desired outcome or goal) so that (impact or benefit)?

Primary research is observing and listening to your target audience.

5 Most Common Methods

Interviews (verbal)

1:1 Interview discussions with open ended questions.

Shadowing (Observe)

Observing someone doing a certain activity or simply doing their day to day activities.

Observing

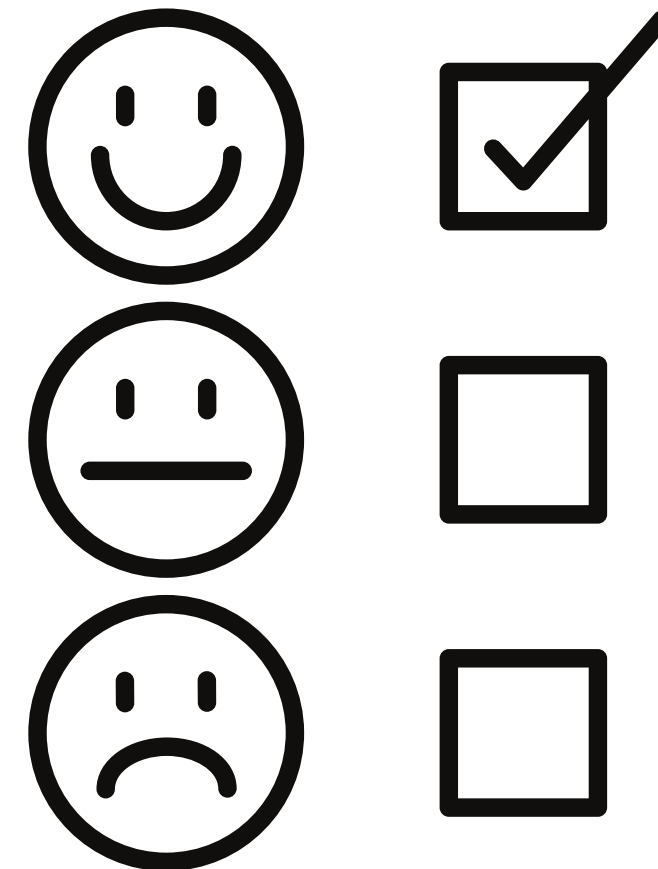
Watching and listening a person in their natural environment.

Survey

Individuals fill out a survey with open ended questions.

Focus Groups

Group of people in which you ask open ended questions.



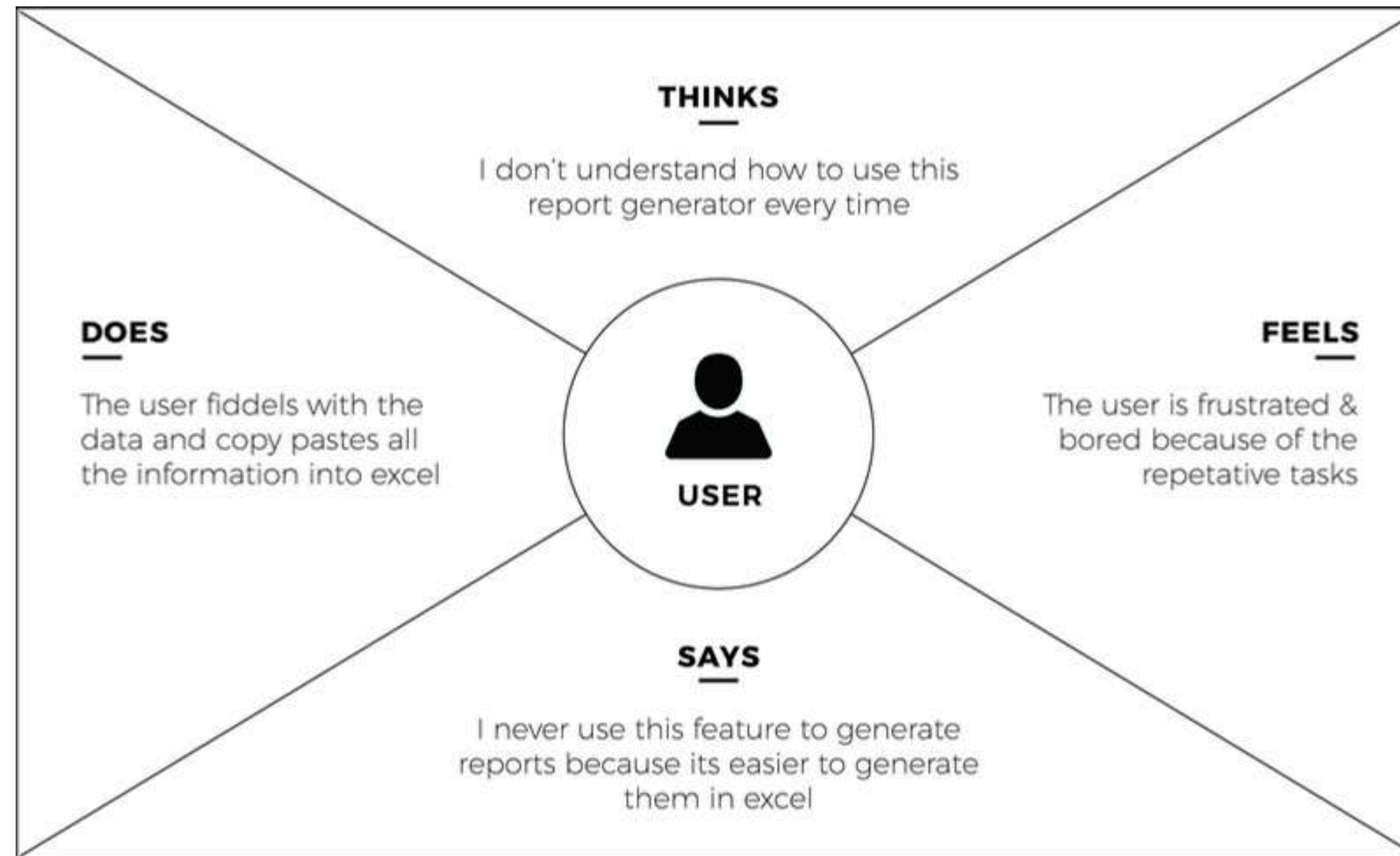
Example of where primary research is used commonly - Cybersecurity.



Class Activity

Which method out of the 5 would be the best?

Empathy Map



Reframe the Problem by Defining Your Personas



Reframe – Who are you helping

User Persona Prompts

Who are they (Age, Gender, Location)?

What are their top pain points/challenges stemming from this problem?

How are they affected? How do they feel when they are affected?

What are they currently doing to cope with the problem?

What is their end goal?

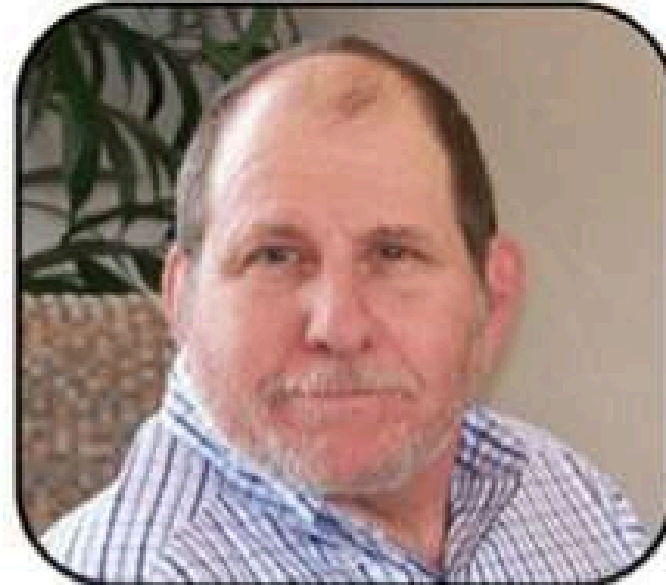


Roman's Persona Template

 PICTURE & NAME	 DETAILS	 GOAL
What does the persona look like? What is its name? Choose a picture and a name that are appropriate and that help you develop sympathy for the persona.	What are the persona's relevant characteristics and behaviours? These may include demographics, job, lifestyle, spare time activities, and common tasks.	Why would the persona want to buy or use the product? What problem should the product solve? What benefit does the persona want to achieve?



Facility/Operations Manager Fred



Personal Background

- Age: 45-55
- Married with 1 kid in College, 1 in HS
- Education: Undergraduate

Role: Facility or Operations Manager

- Job measured: space and operations efficiency, employee productivity
- Skills required: People management, analysis, industry knowledge
- Reports to: CEO or General Manager
- Manages: Operations staff

Company information

- Industry: Distribution, Manufacturing, 3PL
- Yearly Revenue: \$20M
- Employees: 100

Goals and Challenges

- Success means: a raise and promotion
- Values most: Job security, family, recognition for success, church
- Biggest challenges: New systems, managing people, keeping all balls in air
- Biggest objections: Appearance, liability, suitability, not state of the art, look dumb

Shopping and Industry News Preferences

- Preferred communication: Email, phone
- Use internet for buying research: Much
- Gets updated industry news: Specific industry publication
- Industry publications: Trade magazines
- Industry associations: Industry trade groups
- Social networking sites: LinkedIn?

Sample Client Persona Home Buyer

Background

- Hometown in Massachusetts
- Has two cats
- Drives a reliable minivan
- Second-time home buyer
- Interested in a larger home

Identifiers

- Active on Social Media
- Willing to reach out via email
- Expects a fair amount of customer service

Goals

- Desire to upsize her home for her growing and active family
- Interested in a pre-sale/partially-finished home in a neighborhood so she can add custom features and make color selections
- Would like to make a few changes to existing floorplan

Demographics

- Age 38
- Three children
- Civilian schoolteacher married to a higher-ranking active-duty service member

Spends Online Time On

- Pinterest
- Email
- Facebook

Challenges

- Military timelines
- Busy schedule

Favorite Tech

- iPhone
- Google Home
- Fitbit



Jordan Young

Interests

- Home Decor
- Reading and visiting bookstores or libraries
- Painting
- Roasting coffee

Brands

ANTHROPOLOGIE



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Jordan Young

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Brands



What can we use here to differentiate from other real estate agents?

How to Collect Persona Data

Options

- Email
- Online Surveys e.g. Google Form or Survey Monkey
- In-Person (virtual) Interviews
- Focus Groups

Any other options?

Ask open-ended questions!



Analyze Data, Interpret Needs and Find Patterns

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What does your persona need most?



User Persona

Problem:

- Income Stability

Who:

- 4 in 10 Canadians worry about it

Impact:

- Eroding consumer confidence
- Increased debt
- Negative impacts on the economy

Instead of income stability, look at...

What does Julie need?

- Julie is a 45-year-old middle manager who works hard dealing with the constant demands of her job. **BIO**
- She is a single mother who has two young children. **BIO**
- She is living pay cheque to pay cheque. **BIO**
- Julie is concerned about keeping her job in a very disruptive business environment. **PAIN POINT**
- She is too young to retire and too old to start all over. **PAIN POINT**
- “I need to keep current with new ideas and concepts that will help me in the workplace and keep me relevant”. **END GOAL**
- She knows she needs additional education and signs up for local workshops but is too tired, too busy or just running late to participate. **END GOAL**
- Workshops cost money that Julie does not have to spare. **PAIN POINT**
- Her daughters need help with homework in the evenings.
- Anxiety - “I’m worried about the future”, “I feel helpless and alone”. **FEELING**

Validating Your Persona

Share and socialize!

Ongoing, iterative process of refinement.

“DON’T think your Persona is everybody”



Prioritizing Your Personas

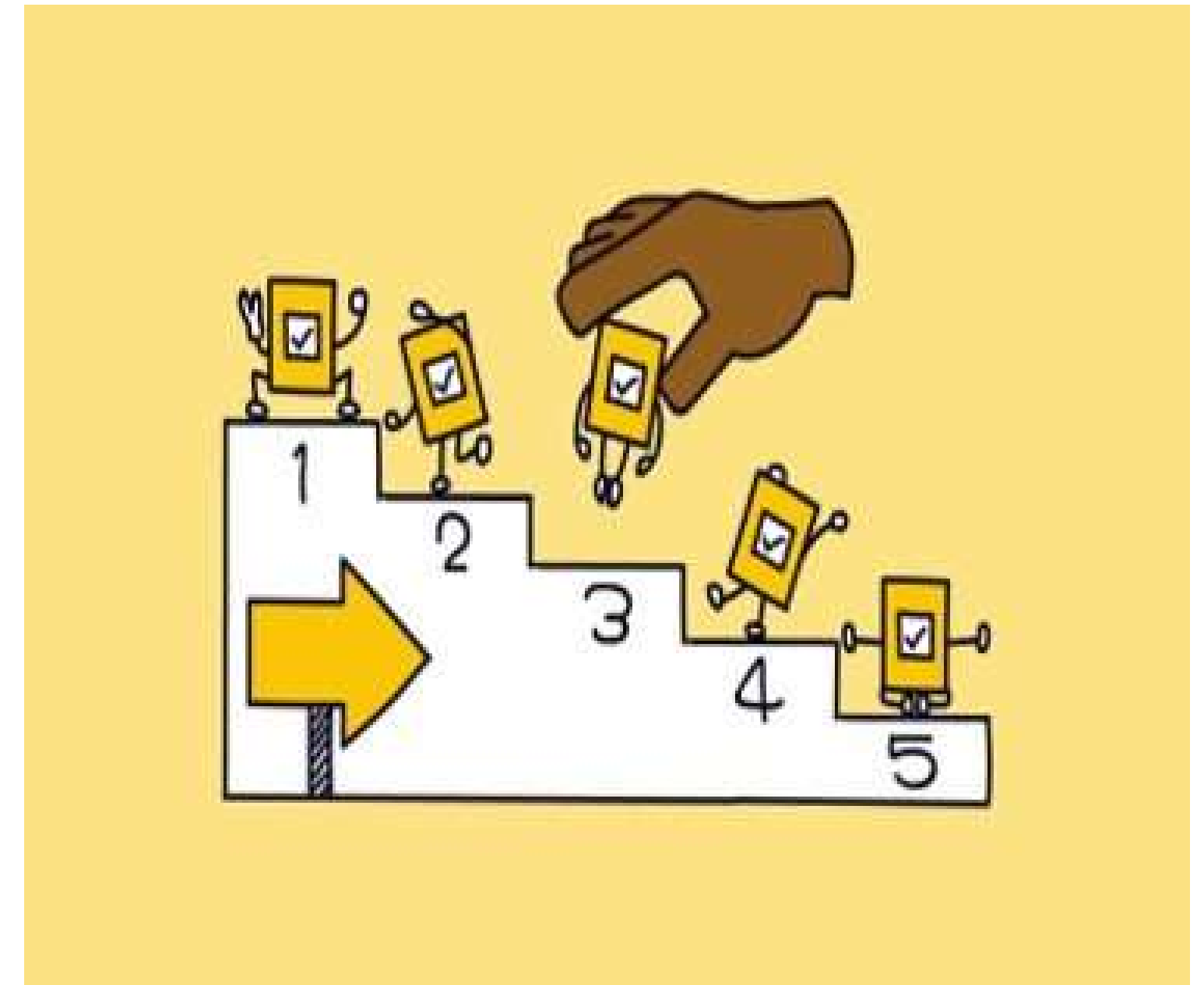
Define your criteria and evaluate.

Sample criteria:

- % of user population;
- % of interactions;
- Paying vs non-paying users;
- Influencers vs regular users.

Communicate and get feedback.

Refine and iterate.



Beware of the “Mom Test”

- Do not “ask your mom whether your business is a good idea, because she loves you and will lie to you.”
 - Limit # of Personas to ≤ 5
 - Personas do not address the needs of everyone.
 - They help you focus on your important user groups.
 - Focus on the main goal of a Persona
 - A Persona most likely has multiple goals; focus on the one that makes the Persona want to use your product.
 - Prioritizing Personas helps define product roadmap
 - Other benefits: sales and marketing efforts (e.g. demographics); web site contents; metrics (e.g. % of population) etc.



B2C (business-to-consumer)

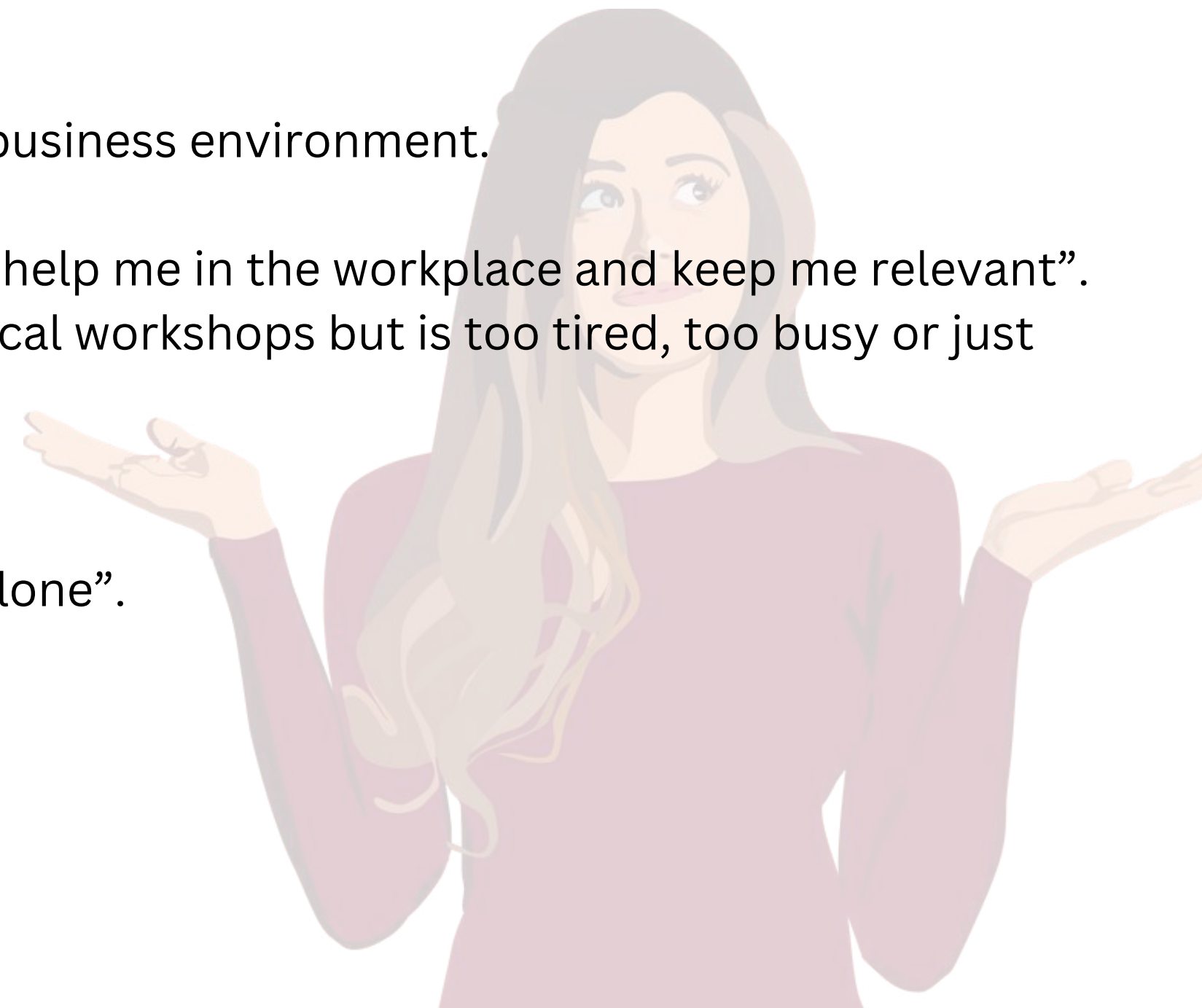
- B2C (business-to-consumer)
- User = buyer: Selling directly to an end consumer e.g. shoppers at a store, users/players of a gaming app

B2B (business-to-business)

- User <> buyer: Selling to an organization with multiple roles, decision makers and buyers – ex. bookkeeping specialist; financial controller; CFO etc.
- Other examples: B2G (business-to-government)

Instead of income stability...reframe

- Julie is a 45-year-old middle manager who works hard dealing with the constant demands of her job.
- She is a single mother who has two young children.
- She is living pay cheque to pay cheque.
- Julie is concerned about keeping her job in a very disruptive business environment.
- She is too young to retire and does not want to start all over.
- “I need to keep current with new ideas and concepts that will help me in the workplace and keep me relevant”.
- She knows she needs additional education and signs up for local workshops but is too tired, too busy or just running late to participate.
- Workshops cost money that Julie does not have to spare.
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How could we...

How could we develop a no/low cost, on-demand, flexible program that would:

- Provide Julie relevant tools to assist her in her job;
- Build her resilience;
- Introduce her to a like minded community?

What does Julie need?



Activity: Suggest Possible Solutions

How could we develop a no/low cost, on-demand, flexible program that would:

- Provide Julie relevant tools to assist her in her job;
- Build her resilience;
- Introduce her to a like minded community?

What are some solutions that we could brainstorm?



Career Recharge

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Seneca was posed the problem statement of “Income Security” by TD Bank

We responded by developing the Julie persona that lead us to the development of Career Recharge as a solution.

Career Recharge is a free, innovative initiative to help you prepare for your future. Whether you are re-entering the workforce, looking for advancement or changing your career, we’re here to help with free supports and resources.

Supported by the TD Ready Commitment, Career Recharge offers workshops and on-demand content designed to help individuals develop key skills for today's economy.



Design Thinking is Iterative

Design Thinking is Iterative

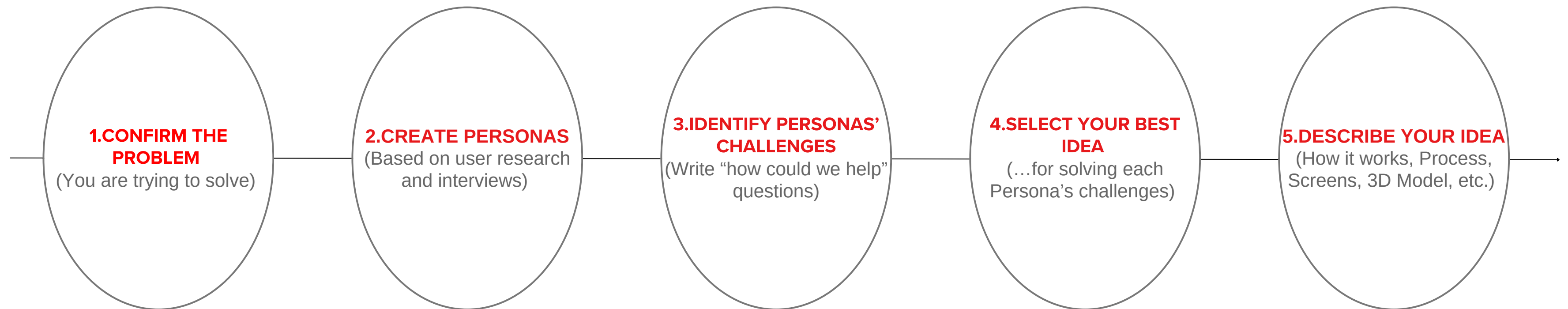
Define, validate and prioritize Personas
for your proposed product or service.



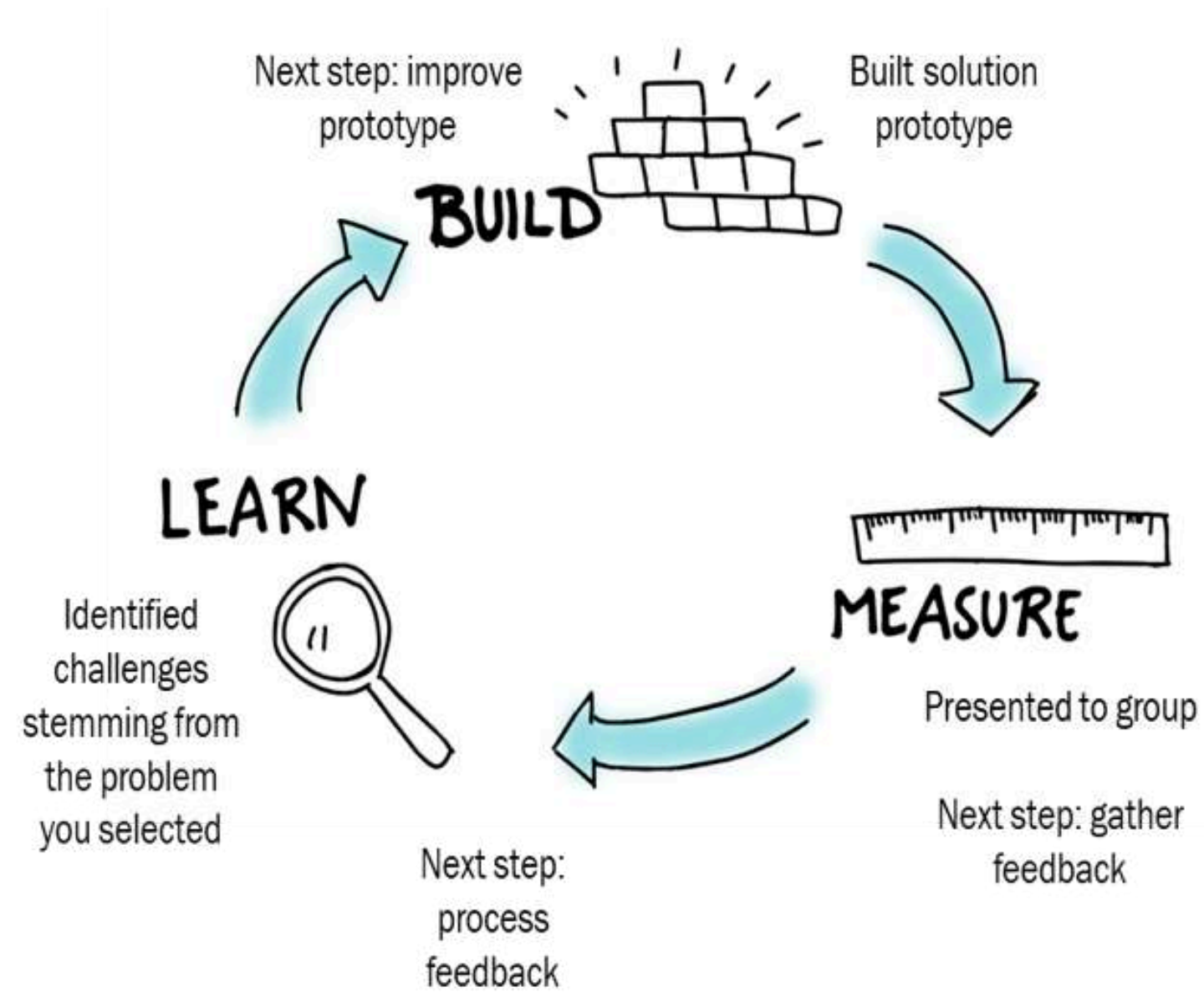
Design Thinking is Iterative

Create Personas & Solutions

Create **Personas**



Design Thinking is Iterative



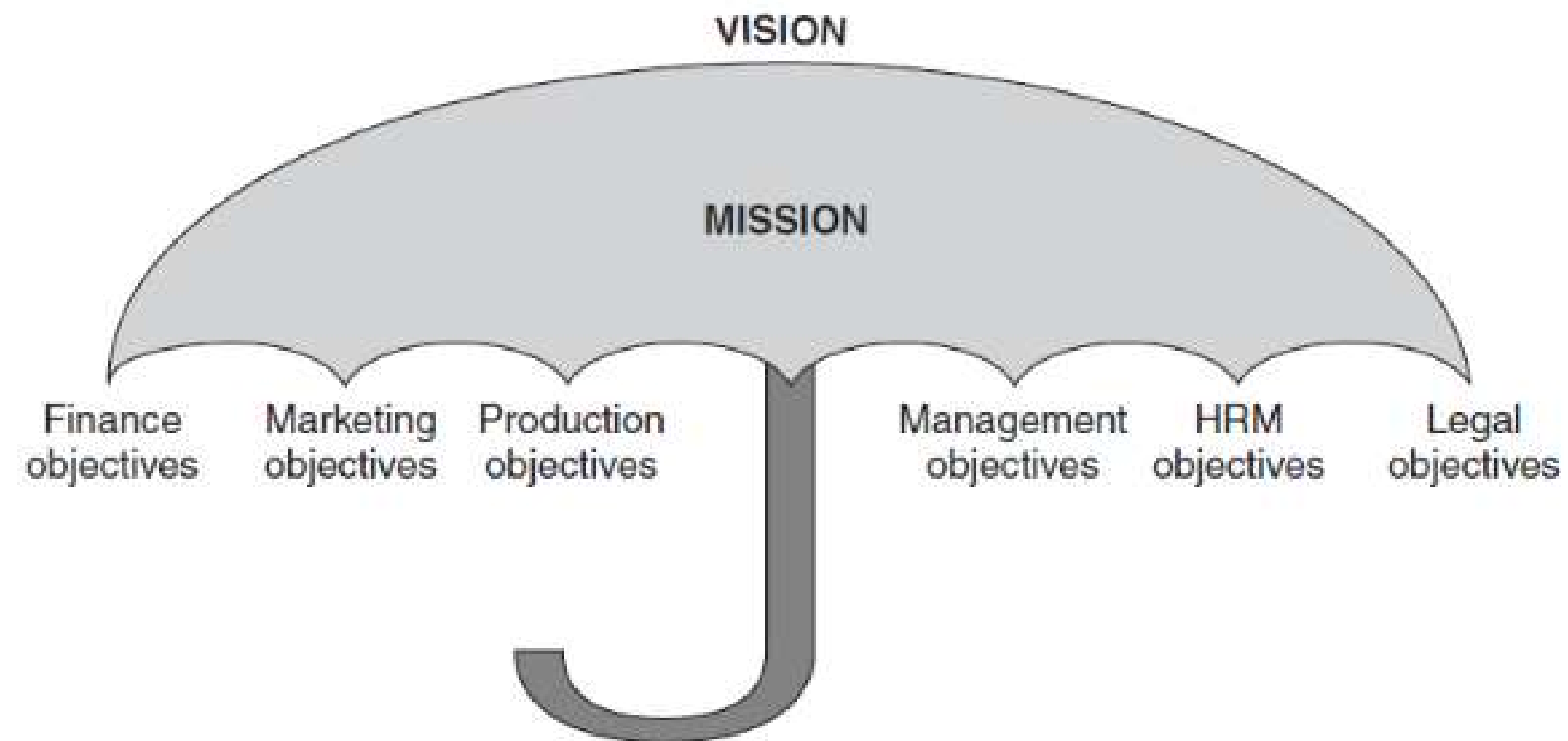
Vision

Explains what the business is stressing to become in the future.

Mission Statement

Defines the present business scope and broadly describes the organization's present capabilities, focus, and activities.

Strategic Umbrella



Mission and Vision

TESLA



Vision

To accelerate the world's transition to sustainable energy.

Mission Statement

To create the most compelling car company of the 21st century by driving the world's transition to electric vehicles.

Mission and Vision

Google



Vision

To provide access to the world's information in one click.

Mission Statement

To organize the world's information and make it universally accessible and useful.

Mission and Vision





Vision

To create economic opportunity for every member of the global workforce.

Mission Statement

To connect the world's professionals to make them more productive and successful.

1. Identify and list 5 blogs/news outlets that focus on your specific topic/field of study/industry. No descriptions required.
2. Identify 5 social media influencers/influential pages in your space (topic/field of study/industry). No description required.

Attach as a word doc/pdf in your email submission.

Workbook 2 - Personas

2 Questions

PMReady Module 2

Please submit onto Blackboard

Hint: You may use AI to validate your User Persona; however, try your best to find real people you can speak to. Refer to the LinkedIn module under the “Program Documents” folder on Blackboard for support

HELIX INNOVATION STRAND WORKBOOK

IDEATION

IDEATION **LEARNING OUTCOMES**

**Empathize and
define problems**



**Create ideas for
solving the problems**

IDEATION PROCESS



IDEATION PROCESS



? What problem do you want to solve?

A large, empty, rounded rectangular box intended for writing or drawing.

IDEATION PROCESS



? Problem Identified !

Who does the problem effect?

Who does the problem effect?

Who does the problem effect?

(You can write up to 14 lines in each box)

IDEATION PROCESS



? Problem Identified !

Group 1

How is group 1 effected?

Group 2

How is group 2 effected?

Group 3

How is group 3 effected?

IDEATION **RESOURCES**



Design Thinking



Stanford D.School



Government of Canada COVID-19 Challenges



Golden Rules of Ideation

HELIX INNOVATION STRAND WORKBOOK

PERSONA

PERSONA

LEARNING
OUTCOMES

**Define, validate
and prioritize
personas for
your proposed
product or
service.**



PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **personas** & **solutions**

Create **personas**



Create **solutions**

PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **personas**

Create **personas**



1. CONFIRM
THE
PROBLEM
(You are trying
to solve)

Instruction: Summarize the problem
you identified in IDEATION.

PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **personas**

Create **personas**

1. CONFIRM
THE
PROBLEM
(You are trying
to solve)

2. CREATE
PERSONAS
(Based on user
research and
interviews)

3. IDENTIFY
PERSONAS'
CHALLENGES
(Write "how
could we help"
questions)

2. CREATE
PERSONAS
(Based on user
research and
interviews)

Instruction: Provide detailed personal and business background information of this persona based on data collected from user research and interviews. (You can

base your answer on information

from "Who does the problem affect?" in step 2 of the IDEATION

PERSONA 1

PERSONA 2

PERSONA 3

PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **personas**

Create **personas**

1. CONFIRM
THE
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could we help"
questions)

3. IDENTIFY
PERSONAS'
CHALLENGES
(Write "how
could we help"
questions)

Instruction: What frustrates this
persona? What stands in the way
of their goal? (You can use
information from "how is this
group affected?" in step 3 of the
IDEATION Process)

PERSONA 1'S
CHALLENGES

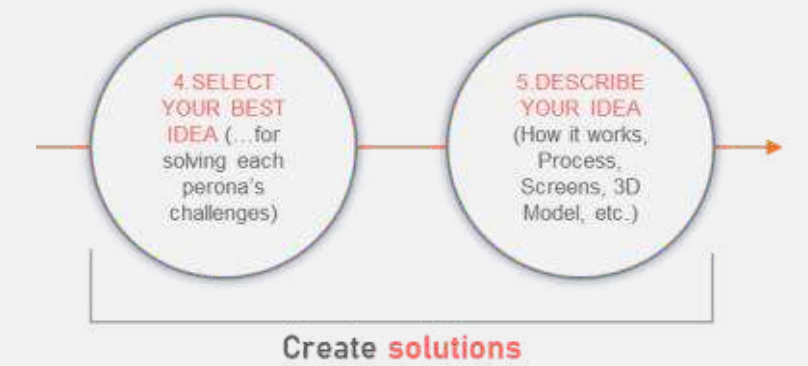
PERSONA 2'S
CHALLENGES

PERSONA 3'S
CHALLENGES

PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **solutions**



4. SELECT YOUR BEST IDEA (...for solving each persona's challenges)

Instruction: Select your best (most viable, least expensive, etc.) that can help to resolve personas' problems and/or satisfy their needs.

PERSONA 1's SOLUTION

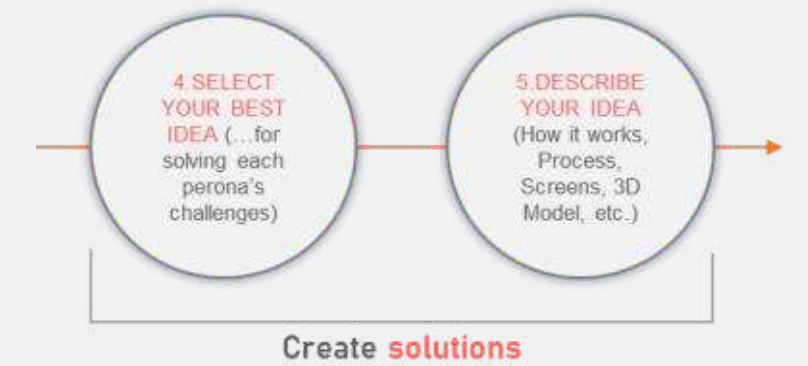
PERSONA 2's SOLUTION

PERSONA 3's SOLUTION

PERSONA

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Create **solutions**



5. DESCRIBE
YOUR IDEA
(How it works,
Process,
Screens, 3D
Model, etc.)

Instruction: Describe your idea (in details) and how it can help to resolve a persona's problems and/or satisfy their needs.

PERSONA 1's DETAILS
ON SOLUTION

PERSONA 2's DETAILS
ON SOLUTION

PERSONA 3's DETAILS
ON SOLUTION

PERSONA RESOURCES

HOW MUCH IS AN IDEA WORTH?



[How much is an idea alone worth](#)

PERSONA: WHAT AND WHY?



[Personas](#)



[How to create user personas for your business](#)

PERSONA EXAMPLES



[4 Persona example you can use in any Industry](#)



[How to Create Detailed Buyer Personas for Your Business](#)



[5 essentials for your user persona template \(with examples\)](#)

TIPS ON CREATING PERSONAS



[10 tips for more effective user personas](#)